



STEADY

*a field guide for
the nervous system*

A COMPANION TO THE ALIGNMENT MIRROR

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STEADY

a field guide for the nervous system

Open this when something is wrong.

This is not a book to read.

It is a book to open when something is wrong in your
body and your mind has gone too fast to help.

There are no chapters. There are states. Find the one
that matches what is happening, do one small thing
on the page, then close it.

You do not have to do it well. You only have to do it
for ninety seconds.



If you are not sure which state you are in

Read the cues. Stop at the first one that lands.

SPINNING

Heart fast. Thoughts racing. Wanting to do, fix, leave, fight, run.

FROZEN

Stuck. Holding your breath. Watching yourself from outside. Cannot move.

NUMB

Heavy. Far away. Eyes glazed. Don't care. Cannot feel the room.

PERFORMING

Smiling when you don't mean it. Saying yes. Tracking everyone's face but your own.

I



Spinning

when the body wants to run and there is nowhere to go

SPINNING

The cues

what it looks like in your body

Heart hammering.

Thoughts in loops.

Restless hands.

Wanting to leave the room.

Picking a fight with someone safe.



Cold water

Run your wrists under cold water for thirty seconds. Then your face. Cold is the fastest off-switch your body has.

ninety seconds is enough



Long exhale

Breathe in for four. Out for eight. Twice as long
out as in. Do it six times.

ninety seconds is enough



Push a wall

Both palms flat against a wall. Push like you mean it for thirty seconds. Let your body use the fuel it is making.

ninety seconds is enough



Name five things

Five things you can see. Four you can touch.
Three you can hear. Two you can smell. One you
can taste. Out loud if you can.

ninety seconds is enough



Walk it out

Ten minutes, no phone, no destination. Fast at first. Slower at the end.

ninety seconds is enough



SPINNING

After

The body was preparing to run from something
it could not name. You gave it somewhere to go.



II



Frozen

when the body has locked the door from the inside

FROZEN

The cues

what it looks like in your body

Holding your breath without noticing.

Watching yourself from above.

Cannot make a decision.

Cannot speak.

Body feels small and far.



Find your feet

Press both feet into the floor. Push down hard.
Feel the floor push back. Stay there for one
minute.

ninety seconds is enough



Orient

Slowly turn your head. Look at six things around you. Name each one out loud. You are in this room. You are not where it started.

ninety seconds is enough



Hum

Close your mouth. Hum a low note for as long as one breath lasts. Three times. The vibration tells your body it is safe enough to make sound.

ninety seconds is enough



Move one small thing

Wiggle your toes. Then your fingers. Then your jaw. The frozen part does not have to thaw all at once.

ninety seconds is enough



Warm weight

A blanket, a heating pad, a heavy book on your chest. Pressure tells the body someone is here.

ninety seconds is enough



FROZEN

After

Frozen is not weakness. It is the oldest
protection your body has. You are allowed to
come back slowly.



III



Numb

when the lights are on and no one is home

NUMB

The cues

what it looks like in your body

Heavy limbs.

Cannot care about anything.

Eyes unfocused.

Cannot feel hunger, cold, or time.

Want to disappear into a screen.



Sour or sharp

A lemon wedge. A piece of ginger. A strong
mint. Something the mouth cannot ignore.

ninety seconds is enough



Stand up

Just stand up. Out of the chair. Out of the bed.
Stay standing for one minute. That is the whole
task.

ninety seconds is enough



Sun on skin

A window. A doorway. Two minutes of light
directly on your face.

ninety seconds is enough



Tell one person one true thing

A text is enough. "I am not okay today" counts.
You do not have to explain.

ninety seconds is enough



Drink something warm

Hold the cup in both hands. Feel the heat. Drink
it slowly. That is the practice.

ninety seconds is enough



NUMB

After

Numb is the body conserving what it has left.
You are not gone. You are waiting for it to be
safe enough to come back.



IV



Performing

when you are smiling at someone who is hurting you

PERFORMING

The cues

what it looks like in your body

Saying yes when the answer is no.

Laughing at things that aren't funny.

Tracking everyone's mood but your own.

Apologising for taking up space.

Feeling like you are watching yourself act.



Find the no

Put a hand on your sternum. Ask, quietly: what am I about to agree to that I do not want? Wait for the answer. It usually comes.

ninety seconds is enough



Excuse yourself

Bathroom. Outside. Anywhere with a door. Five minutes alone is a complete sentence.

ninety seconds is enough



Drop the mask for one breath

Let your face do whatever it actually wants to do,
just for one inhale. Even if no one sees it.

Especially if no one sees it.

ninety seconds is enough



Buy time

"Let me get back to you on that." "I need to think." "Not today." These are full answers.

ninety seconds is enough



Leave early

You do not need a reason. Tired is a reason.

Done is a reason. No reason is a reason.

ninety seconds is enough



PERFORMING

After

The mask kept you safe once. It does not have to
be the only face you wear.



A last thing

You did not earn the body you have by being calm.

You earned it by surviving.

Steady is not a place you arrive at. It is a place you
keep coming back to, ninety seconds at a time.

